Ruling Ideas

A 25-minute team game on Marx. Rules on page 3, trivia on the Host Sheet and website, money in the currency PDF.

THE BIG QUESTION

Are the rules we live by natural and permanent, or made by people and changeable?

The goals, how the discussions connect, and the closing message are on page 2.

Your three jobs

Host: runs the website (or reads the Host Sheet) and counts “3, 2, 1.”

Banker (plays “the State”): holds all the tokens at the start, pays teams, and enforces whatever rule the Ruling Class picks.

Historian: judges close answers and explains what each round means.

The four teams

Team	Who you are	What your reading says
Team 1 Factory Workers	The modern working class, packed into factories and cities by big industry. *(Communist Manifesto)*	*The Manifesto says the real fruit of workers’ battles is “the ever-expanding union of the workers.”*
Team 2 Guild Artisans	Medieval craftsmen and shopkeepers, squeezed out by big industry. *(Communist Manifesto)*	*The Manifesto says the lower middle class fights big business only to save itself: “they try to roll back the wheel of history.”*
Team 3 Pin Makers	Adam Smith’s ten workers, each doing one small step of making a pin. *(Wealth of Nations)*	*Smith says ten workers who split up the job can make upwards of 48,000 pins a day. Marx agrees it’s productive, but asks who ends up owning the pins.*
Team 4 Bedouin	Ibn Khaldun’s desert tribe, held together by group feeling. *(Muqaddimah)*	*Ibn Khaldun says desert peoples have the strongest group feeling, which is why they conquer cities, until city luxury softens them too.*

The game at a glance (then a short debrief and closing message)

Round	What happens	What it teaches
1. WORK 4 min	Questions 1–5: “Who said it?” with Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx. The team with the most tokens becomes the Ruling Class.	*Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx agree more than you’d expect, and the quotes prove it.*
2. RULE 6 min with discussion	The Ruling Class picks a Rule Card and says why it’s “good for everyone.” Then questions 6–10 on the Theses and the Manifesto.	*The Manifesto calls the state “a committee for managing the common affairs of the whole bourgeoisie.” The Ruling Class writes the rules and the State enforces them.*
3. WAGES 6 min with discussion	The Ruling Class can’t answer the Hard Questions. The other teams undercut each other for the job, and the reward goes to the Ruling Class.	*The worker is “a commodity, like every other article of commerce.” Competition between workers pushes wages down, and the profit goes to someone else.*
4. REVOLUTION 4 min	The Ruling Class may bribe one team to sit out. The rest answer one prompt together. If they win, everyone shares the prize.	*A revolution needs the workers to stay united, and a ruling class survives by splitting them.*

The Big Idea

What the whole presentation argues, how the discussions build on each other, and what to say at the end.

The big question

Are the rules we live by natural and permanent, or made by people and changeable?

Players' goal: Finish the game holding the prize. The Ruling Class wins by keeping power. Everyone else wins only by overthrowing it together. **Our goal:** By the end, everyone can answer that question the way Marx does, with evidence from the Theses on Feuerbach and the Manifesto.

How the discussions connect

Each discussion answers part of the big question and sets up the next round. Give each one a 1-minute timer.

When	Discussion question (1-minute timer)	Where we land	Then say
Round 1 warm-up	No discussion. "Who said it?" shows Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx all tie society to how people make a living.	—	*Pick the Ruling Class.*
Discussion 1 after Round 2	1. Why does the state develop in a way that promotes inequality and keeps so many of its people in a bad state? 2. Why do people who are hurt by these systems accept it? 3. What can be a solution? 4. How does this link to ideas turning into action?	The state protects whoever controls production, people accept it because those rules are made to feel natural and competition divides them, and change comes only when ideas turn into shared action.	*Round 3 will show you how that competition works.*
Discussion 2 after Round 3	In Round 3 you undercut each other, even though it only helped the Ruling Class. Why don't the people the rules hurt just change them, and what would it take?	Competition keeps the people who lose divided. Changing the rules takes acting together.	*Round 4 is your chance to try.*
Round 4 the test	The other teams try to change the rules together.	Either they win together, or the Ruling Class splits them.	*Go to the debrief.*

The overarching message

For Marx, the rules of society are made, not natural. Whoever controls production writes them and calls them fair, and they last until the people living under them act together to change them.

Where students can push back: Ibn Khaldun would say every united group that takes power eventually becomes the new ruling group. Smith would say market rules, driven by self-interest, make almost everyone richer. Is Marx right that this time is different?

Closing script (about one minute, after the debrief table)

> Today we asked one question: are the rules we live by natural, or made? Round 1 showed that Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx all tie society to how people make a living. Round 2 showed who writes the rules: the Ruling Class wrote a rule, called it good for everyone, and the State enforced it, just as the Manifesto describes the state as a committee for the bourgeoisie. Round 3 showed why the rules survive: you competed against each other for wages instead of uniting. Round 4 was your chance to change them together. That is Marx's whole argument in these two readings: the rules are made, the people who benefit call them natural, and only people acting together can change them. Thesis XI puts it in one line: the point is not just to interpret the world, but to change it.

End on: "The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways; the point, however, is to change it." That's why we played instead of just reading.

The Rules

13 short rules. Read them once before class; the website shows them too.

Before you start

1. Tokens are the Bank of Han Xue notes in the currency PDF. Each note says one million but counts as 1 token, since money is arbitrary anyway. The Banker starts with all 60, gives each team 3, and keeps the rest.
2. Each team gets its Identity Card, scrap paper and a pen. Put the prize (candy) where everyone can see it.

Answering

3. The Host reads a question. After 20 seconds, everyone holds up their answer on “3, 2, 1.”
4. Every team that’s right gets 1 token from the Banker.
5. After Rounds 2 and 3, the Historian asks one discussion question and runs a 1-minute timer.

Round 1: Work

6. Play questions 1–5. The team with the most tokens becomes the Ruling Class and gets the placard. If there’s a tie, the closest guess on the tiebreaker wins.

Round 2: Rule

7. The Ruling Class picks one Rule Card and finishes the sentence “This rule is good for everyone because…” The Banker enforces it for the rest of the game.
8. Play questions 6–10. Everyone answers, including the Ruling Class.

Round 3: Wages

9. The Ruling Class can’t answer the Hard Question. The other teams call out lower and lower wages (3, 2, 1, 0) to do it, and the lowest offer gets the job.
10. The Ruling Class pays that wage. If the answer is right, the Banker gives 3 tokens to the Ruling Class, not to the team that answered. Play two Hard Questions.

Round 4: Revolution

11. First, the Ruling Class may offer 2 tokens to one team. If that team takes the Bribe, it sits out the revolution.
12. All the other teams answer one Revolution Prompt together, one sentence per team. The Historian judges.
13. If the revolution wins, the placard is torn up and everyone except a bribed team shares the prize. If it fails, the Ruling Class and any bribed team share it.

Host Sheet

Read each question aloud, give 20 seconds, then count "3, 2, 1." The same questions are on the website.

Round 1: Work (Who said it?)

1. "It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker, that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest." **A)** Karl Marx **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: B) Adam Smith (Wealth of Nations, Book I) *Why it matters: The Manifesto describes the same thing as "naked self-interest" and "callous cash payment." Same fact, opposite verdict.*

2. The bourgeoisie "has accomplished wonders far surpassing Egyptian pyramids, Roman aqueducts, and Gothic cathedrals." **A)** Karl Marx **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: A) Marx and Engels (Manifesto, Section I) *Why it matters: That's Marx, not Smith, praising capitalism. Hold that thought: it's the first discussion question.*

3. Differences between peoples come from "the different ways in which they make their living." **A)** Karl Marx **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: C) Ibn Khaldun (Muqaddimah, Chapter 2) *Why it matters: How people make a living shapes who they are. Ibn Khaldun said it more than 450 years before Marx.*

4. Doing a few simple tasks all day can make a worker "as stupid and ignorant as it is possible for a human creature to become." **A)** Karl Marx **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: B) Adam Smith (Wealth of Nations, Book V) *Why it matters: The Manifesto says the same worker becomes "an appendage of the machine." Smith's fix is schooling; Marx's is ending the system.*

5. "The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways; the point, however, is to change it." **A)** Karl Marx **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: A) Marx (Theses on Feuerbach, Thesis XI) *Why it matters: The most famous line in the Theses, and the theme of this game: next round, someone gets to change the rules.*

Round 2: Rule (under the new rule)

6. In Thesis VI, what does Marx say the human essence really is? **A)** Reason, which every person is born with **B)** The ensemble of the social relations **C)** A soul given by God

Answer: B) The ensemble of the social relations *Why it matters: No fixed human nature: you are your relationships. In this game, too, what matters is whether your team rules, not what it's called.*

7. The Manifesto compares modern bourgeois society to someone who can "no longer control the powers of the nether world" they called up. Who? **A)** A king **B)** A sorcerer **C)** A gambler

Answer: B) A sorcerer *Why it matters: Capitalism's own productive power runs out of control in crises of over-production.*

8. The Manifesto says the executive of the modern state is a committee for managing the common affairs of… **A)** the whole people **B)** the whole bourgeoisie **C)** the working class

Answer: B) the whole bourgeoisie *Why it matters: That's why our Banker plays the State: it enforces whatever the Ruling Class decides.*

9. In the Manifesto, what does "All that is solid melts into air" describe? **A)** Capitalism constantly overturning how people work and live **B)** A workers' revolution destroying the state **C)** Feudal lords losing their castles

Answer: A) Capitalism constantly overturning how people work and live *Why it matters: The bourgeoisie "cannot exist without constantly revolutionising the instruments of production," so nothing stays fixed for long.*

10. Thesis II says the question of whether human thinking is true is a question of… **A)** theory **B)** practice **C)** faith

Answer: B) practice *Why it matters: You prove an idea is true by acting on it. Arguing about it in the abstract is, for Marx, "purely scholastic."*

Tiebreaker (only if Round 1 ends in a tie; closest guess wins)

In what year was The German Ideology, the book the Theses were written for, first published? Closest guess wins.

Answer: 1932 *Why it matters: Marx and Engels left the manuscript to "the gnawing criticism of the mice."*

Round 3: Wages (Hard Questions, 30 seconds each)

Open the wage at 3 and let teams undercut each other. The Ruling Class may not answer.

H1. The Manifesto says the bourgeoisie gets out of economic crises in two ways. Name both.

Answer: Destroying a mass of productive forces; conquering new markets and exploiting old ones more thoroughly. Both set up bigger crises later.

H2. The Manifesto says the workers' fight grows in stages. Name any two.

Answer: Single workers, then a whole factory, then one trade in one place; smashing machines and imported goods; forming trade unions; uniting into one national struggle and a political party.

Round 4: Revolution prompts (pick one)

The other teams answer together, one sentence per team. The Historian decides if they win.

P1. The Manifesto says the bourgeoisie produces "its own grave-diggers." Explain how, in two steps.

Answer: (1) Industry creates a mass working class and packs it into factories and cities. (2) Railways and communication connect the workers, so competition turns into union, which overthrows the system.

P2. Smith says people have a natural "propensity to truck, barter, and exchange." How would Marx answer him?

Answer: Marx would say that isn't human nature, it's a product of one kind of society. For him the human essence is "the ensemble of the social relations," and the Manifesto shows the bourgeoisie made "naked self-interest" the only bond between people. It's historical, so it can change.

Historian Sheet

After Rounds 2 and 3, ask that round's discussion question and run a 1-minute timer. Use the hints from the readings if the room goes quiet.

Discussion question 1 (after Round 2): Who writes the rules, and why do people accept them?

1. Why does the state develop in a way that promotes inequality and keeps so many of its people in a bad state?

From the readings: The Manifesto calls the state "a committee for managing the common affairs of the whole bourgeoisie" (p. 475). Our Banker enforced the Ruling Class's rule the same way.

2. Why do people who are hurt by these systems accept it?

From the readings: The ruling class's ideas feel like everyone's ideas, and its rule gets called "good for everyone." Workers' unity is also "continually being upset" by competition between them (p. 481).

3. What can be a solution?

From the readings: The Manifesto's answer is "the ever-expanding union of the workers" (p. 481). Others would point to voting, unions, or laws like the ten-hours' bill.

4. How does this link to ideas turning into action?

From the readings: Thesis XI: "the point, however, is to change it." Thesis II: an idea is proved true only in practice.

Where we land: The state protects whoever controls production, people accept it because those rules are made to feel natural and competition divides them, and change comes only when ideas turn into shared action. *Round 3 will show you how that competition works.*

Discussion question 2 (after Round 3): What stops people from changing the rules?

In Round 3 you undercut each other, even though it only helped the Ruling Class. Why don't the people the rules hurt just change them, and what would it take?

From the readings: Workers' unity is "continually being upset again by the competition between the workers themselves," but it "ever rises up again" (Manifesto, p. 481). Thesis III: people are shaped by circumstances, but "it is men who change circumstances."

Where we land: Competition keeps the people who lose divided. Changing the rules takes acting together. *Round 4 is your chance to try.*

Debrief (after Round 4)

If the revolution won: "You won together, the Manifesto's "ever-expanding union of the workers." And nobody replaced the Ruling Class. That's Marx's big claim: this revolution ends class rule itself."

If the ruling Class survived: "The bribe or a weak answer saved the rulers. The Manifesto says workers' unity is "continually being upset" by competition between them, and the ruling class uses that."

What you just played

What happened in the game	What it shows	Where it's from
The leader wrote the rules	The ruling class's ideas become everyone's ideas	German Ideology, p. 172
The "good for everyone" speech	Every class dresses up its interest as the common interest	German Ideology, p. 174
The Banker enforced it	The state as "a committee" for the bourgeoisie	Manifesto, p. 475
Teams undercut each other	Competition between workers pushes wages down	Manifesto, p. 479
The worker team didn't get the 3	Workers find work only while it "increases capital"	Manifesto, p. 479
Your team name didn't matter, your position did	We are "the ensemble of the social relations"	Thesis VI
The bribe split the teams	Workers' unity is "continually being upset" by competition	Manifesto, p. 481
Teams revolted together	The "ever-expanding union of the workers"	Manifesto, p. 481
We played instead of just reading	"The point, however, is to change it"	Thesis XI

Then close with the message

For Marx, the rules of society are made, not natural. Whoever controls production writes them and calls them fair, and they last until the people living under them act together to change them.

Then read the closing script from The Big Idea page.

Food for thought (last slide: leave these with the class for Friday)

Machines then, AI now. The Manifesto worried that workers would become "an appendage of the machine." When software can do the jobs you're training for, who gets the benefit?

The world in your pocket. Your phone, clothes and coffee probably crossed several borders to reach you. The Manifesto called this the "universal inter-dependence of nations." Is that freedom, or a new kind of dependence?

Natural or made? Think of one rule you've always treated as "just how things are." Who wrote it, and who would lose if it changed?

Ideas into action. Thesis XI says interpreting the world isn't enough. Marx's own ideas went on to reshape the twentieth century, for better and for worse. What does it take for an idea to become action, and who should decide where it leads?

RULING CLASS PLACARD — cut out, fold along the middle line, stand it on the Ruling Class's desk

RULING CLASS

You are the bourgeoisie now. Write the rules.

"The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas."

— The German Ideology

fold here

RULING CLASS

You are the bourgeoisie now. Write the rules.

"The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas."

— The German Ideology

IDENTITY CARDS — cut out and give one to each team at the start

TEAM 1: FACTORY WORKERS

From the Communist Manifesto

The modern working class, packed into factories and cities by big industry.

What your reading says

The Manifesto says the real fruit of workers' battles is "the ever-expanding union of the workers."

If you become the Ruling Class, you play the bourgeoisie.

TEAM 2: GUILD ARTISANS

From the Communist Manifesto

Medieval craftsmen and shopkeepers, squeezed out by big industry.

What your reading says

The Manifesto says the lower middle class fights big business only to save itself: "they try to roll back the wheel of history."

If you become the Ruling Class, you play the bourgeoisie.

TEAM 3: PIN MAKERS

From the Wealth of Nations

Adam Smith's ten workers, each doing one small step of making a pin.

What your reading says

Smith says ten workers who split up the job can make upwards of 48,000 pins a day. Marx agrees it's productive, but asks who ends up owning the pins.

If you become the Ruling Class, you play the bourgeoisie.

TEAM 4: BEDOUIN

From the Muqaddimah

Ibn Khaldun's desert tribe, held together by group feeling.

What your reading says

Ibn Khaldun says desert peoples have the strongest group feeling, which is why they conquer cities, until city luxury softens them too.

If you become the Ruling Class, you play the bourgeoisie.

GAME CARDS — cut along the dashed lines

RULE: DOUBLE PAY

Our right answers earn 2 tokens.

Everyone else still earns 1.

Say: "This rule is good for everyone because…"

RULE: TAX

Every other team pays us 1 token right now.

The Banker collects it for us.

Say: "This rule is good for everyone because…"

THE BRIBE

Ruling Class only, at the start of Round 4.

Give this card and 2 tokens to one team.

If they take it, they sit out the revolution. If it fails, they share your prize. If it wins, they get nothing.

You can rise, but only by joining the rulers.

REVOLUTION

Everyone except the Ruling Class and a bribed team.

Answer one prompt together, one sentence per team.

Win: the placard is torn up and you all share the prize.

Workers of the world, unite!